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Dear Reader,

Let us be the first to thank you for opening this special, returning edition of the *Brown Journal of History*. After a three-year pause coming off of the pandemic, the journal has managed to return this year. We owe this revival to the Brown community, whose students offered us a wealth of amazing material to consider and whose larger network gave us the support we needed to return for Volume XVII. We thank our staff, our authors, the Brown Department of History, and our advisor Benjamin Hein for the work they have put into this edition and restarting BJH.

This year's issue, titled *Journeys*, includes a wide variety of papers spanning swaths of time and space. "Finding Rosicrucianism in Descartes' Writings" by Jazz Carlson '25 traces evidence of Descartes' alleged involvement in the Rosicrucian Brotherhood across his body of work. In "Shielding Choice in Silence: The Women's Escort Service in Providence (1980s–1990s)," Maja Mishevska '27 draws on oral histories and the University archives to tell the story of Providence activists—many of them Brown students—who accompanied women to abortion procedures and consultations in order to shield them from protestors. Owen Blair '26 writes about Medieval Werewolf Masculinities in "Humble Beasts and Violent Knights: Medieval Masculinity in Marie de France's Tale of the Chilvarous Werewolf." Lastly, Desi Silverman-Joseph '27 details in "Roxbury Cowrie: The Shell that Traversed the World" the story of a shell discovered in 2022 on the grounds of the Shirley-Eustis home in Boston, where it likely belonged to an enslaved resident.

At the journal, we see the study and especially the creation of history as beyond its appointed scholars and leaders. With that in mind, *Journeys* highlights intellectual, political, literary, and economic connections between those excluded from a "great man" theory of history. Whether they show how a philosophical titan drew influence from a larger spiritual network or how often unrecognized clinic escorts had a crucial role in politics and safety, we see these pieces as expanding the scope of who we view as involved in history.

The work at this publication this semester at times challenged us but always excited us. Serving as editors of the journal allowed us to see the passion for scholarship and storytelling so vibrant here at Brown, even during a time when the humanities can feel under threat. By reading this edition, we hope you too can see the value for uncovering truth and advancing understanding history offers. Thank you, reader, for being a part of Volume XVII of the *Brown Journal of History*.

Yours truly,

Tyler Tjan & Maria Gomberg
Editors in Chief

1

SHIELDING CHOICE IN SILENCE: THE WOMEN'S ESCORT SERVICE IN PROVIDENCE (1980S–1990S)

By Maja Mishevska

This paper focuses on the role of abortion clinic escorts in the late 1980s and early 1990s, specifically examining the Brown University student-led Women's Escort Service in Providence, Rhode Island. It argues that these escorts acted as silent allies, offering essential support to patients seeking abortion services amid escalating anti-abortion protests. The term 'silent' refers to their choice to remain non-confrontational, refraining from engaging with protesters, while 'allies' emphasizes their active, though unobtrusive, role in prioritizing the safety and comfort of patients through a supportive presence rather than direct confrontation. Drawing on oral histories, archival documents, and secondary sources, the paper explores the escorts' motivations, challenges, and their impact on patient well-being. It highlights their indispensable role in reproductive rights by ensuring safe clinic entry, providing a reassuring presence, and shielding patients from harassment. The paper underscores the importance of grassroots activism in defending reproductive rights and challenges the binary view of activism often promoted by the anti-abortion movement.

"God loves you and we're throwing up all over him with this thing, abortion."[1]
"Abortion, the American Holocaust."[2]
"Take samples home to your mother—for a barbeque."[3]

Anti-abortion protesters hurled these provocative statements at clinic escorts in Providence, reflecting the harsh and hostile environment that abortion seekers and their supporters faced in the 1980s and 1990s. Often volunteers, clinic escorts served as neutral parties who accompanied and safeguarded patients as they entered and exited the facilities. Clinic escorts not only provided immediate care to patients but also, through their role, encapsulated the

1 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, OF-1ZSA-1, Box 3, Folder 9, Brown University Library.
2 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*, Brown Digital Repository, Brown University Library, https://repository.library.brown.edu/studio/item/bdr:715980/.
3 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.

the broader escalating ideological war over reproductive rights during this period. Yet the story of abortion clinic escorts is not one of confrontation but of quiet, steadfast resistance—a commitment to non-engagement with protesters and an unwavering focus on ensuring access to safe reproductive care for patients.

This paper investigates the historical role of abortion clinic escorts, with a specific focus on the Women's Escort Service (WES) in Providence, Rhode Island, during the late 1980s and early 1990s. As anti-abortion protests reached new heights of intensity, these escorts emerged as critical allies for those seeking abortion services. In this paper, I use the term *silent allies* to describe escorts' work, as it captures the essence of their role—tactful, non-confrontational, and focused on making patients feel secure without engaging in direct ideological conflict. By acting as silent allies, escorts shielded patients from physical and emotional harassment, often deflecting hostility onto themselves, while providing practical support free from moral judgment.

The key questions driving this analysis are: How did clinic escorts contribute to reproductive rights efforts by enabling access to abortion services? What day-to-day responsibilities and challenges did clinic escorts face, and how did their silent ally approach differ from more visible pro-choice activism? What emotional and psychological toll did clinic escorts encounter while working in a hostile, high-stress environment, and how did their personal motivations and experiences shape their involvement in the reproductive rights movement?

Through an examination of oral histories, archival documents, newspaper clippings, and testimonies, this paper argues that clinic escorts played a vital, often under-recognized role in safeguarding access to reproductive healthcare. Their work reveals an essential aspect of activism that goes beyond legal and medical frameworks, underscoring the importance of community involvement in preserving abortion services.

The first section of this paper provides the historical context of abortion activism in the United States during the 1980s, examining the rise of anti-abortion protests and how they catalyzed the formation of clinic escort services. The second section delves into the founding of the WES in Providence, exploring the political and social landscape in Rhode Island that influenced its formation. The third section focuses on the routine encounters of clinic escorts, detailing how they trained to navigate the volatile environment outside abortion clinics. This section also analyzes the significance of their 'silent' activism, which anti-abortion protesters often conflated with more outspoken pro-abortion advocacy, showing that the escorts' behind-the-scenes, subtle work does not fit neatly into the binary view—either vehemently vocal in support or opposition—that these protesters frequently promoted. In the final section, I examine escorts' personal experiences to gain insight into the emotional and psychological toll of their work. This section explores the challenges clinic escorts faced, including protesters' violent and bigoted rhetoric, but also addresses escorts' commitment to their work. Their continued efforts despite these difficulties highlights the resilience and dedication that defined the work of escorts.

From Roe to Rescue: The Rise of Anti-Abortion Activism in the 1980s

The landmark *Roe v. Wade* decision of 1973 legalized abortion nationwide, marking a significant victory for reproductive rights. However, this triumph was short-lived. Almost immediately after the ruling, the anti-abortion movement began mobilizing, gaining traction in legal, political, and social spheres. As Lauren Rankin explains, the legalization of abortion had a twofold effect, it both spurred the rapid proliferation of freestanding clinics in states where the procedure had long been criminalized, and "triggered the emergence of a powerful, committed anti[-]abortion movement, one determined to overturn *Roe* at any cost."[4] These counter-movements, fueled by the rise of the Christian right, were instrumental in shaping public discourse and policy, laying the groundwork for the clinic escort's role in protecting access amidst mounting hostile opposition.[5]

By the mid-1970s, anti-abortion activism was characterized by legislative battles, religious and fetal-centric arguments, and anxieties over women's burgeoning professional and sexual freedoms.[6] The movement entered its most radical and militant phase during the 1980s, fueled by formal groups like Operation Rescue (OR), which became "a prototype for ultra-aggressive anti-abortion activism."[7] Active primarily between 1988 and 1992, OR gained prominence for its confrontational

4 Lauren Rankin, *Bodies on the Line: At the Front Lines of the Fight to Protect Abortion in America* (S.L.: Counterpoint, 2023), 15.
5 Paul Saurette and Kelly Gordon, *The Changing Voice of the Anti-Abortion Movement: The Rise of "Pro-Woman" Rhetoric in Canada and the United States* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2016), 65.
6 Ibid., 67.
7 Ibid., 72.

protests, framing abortion as murder and justifying its mission as fulfilling a "Christian duty."[8] By transforming scattered, fringe local protests into a unified national phenomenon, OR expanded the movement geographically and facilitated an ideological shift away from peaceful demonstrations toward aggressive, quasi-violent strategies in the name of "rescu[ing] unborn children."[9]

After its initial deployment in Binghamton, New York, OR spread nationwide, including in Rhode Island, as shown by an undated anti-abortion handout in the WES archive referencing an OR rally in Cranston. The handout instructed anti-abortion activists to "act as if [they] are [their] preborn brother's and sister's keeper."[10] Activists interpreted the Bible's command to "[d]o unto others as you would have them do unto you" as a moral imperative to stop what they viewed as acts of murder.[11] As noted in the WES logs, protesters made reference to threats of an impending OR "sit-in or a 'rescue action,'" with an additional 400 protesters expected to arrive from Boston to join their efforts.[12] By "inundating [clinics] with hundreds of bodies," protesters could physically block entrances and succeed in impeding access.[13] These tactics illustrate how, unlike its predecessors, OR was not merely interested in protesting abortion clinics—it sought to shut them down entirely. The movement's intensified focus on physical obstruction and relentless picketing solidified and perpetuated an environment of intimidation and violence, further eroding the protections originally established by *Roe v. Wade*.

In response to these escalating threats and violence, individual clinics—originally established as safe havens for abortion care—enlisted volunteer escorts to ensure patient safety in the absence of federal government support and law enforcement. Initially, escort services emerged as isolated, ad hoc efforts. With no manuals to follow, early pioneers learned on the ground, using their own bodies to shield patients from screaming protesters, doing what they considered "had to be done."[14] As anti-abortion tactics grew even more extreme—by the end of 1983, there had been more than twenty bombings and arson attacks against abortion clinics—the National Organization for Women (NOW), a feminist advocacy group founded in 1966, stepped in.[15] NOW and its local affiliates provided training and organizational structure to formalize and expand escort programs to cities under increasing threat, adapting to and anticipating blockades. Despite early reservations from some abortion providers, who feared that the presence of escorts might escalate tensions, escort efforts ultimately continued to develop into more structured clinic services, helping staff and patients navigate an increasingly turbulent environment at their front doors.

Yellow Pinnies Arrive in Providence: The Founding of the Women's Escort Service

In Providence, local escalating anti-abortion sentiment led to the establishment of the WES. Despite the strong influence of the Catholic Church—the state's Catholic population was estimated at 90% in 1973—many Rhode Islanders supported keeping the government out of abortion decisions before *Roe v. Wade*.[16] This sentiment is recounted by Lynda Durfee in oral histories from the Pembroke Center, where she reflects on her experience as a Brown student in 1973 and notes a broad public preference for personal autonomy over state intervention in reproductive matters.[17] Nonetheless, the vocal minority began to gain traction. By the 1980s, anti-abortion protests in Providence mirrored the national trend of increasingly militant rhetoric, as the Christian right's discourse became more ideologically fused with intense opposition to abortion.[18] Rhode Island also faced significant barriers to abortion access, as between 1982 and 1992, only one new clinic was established, exacerbating the challenges for those seeking reproductive healthcare in the state.[19]

8 Saurette and Gordon, *The Changing Voice of the Anti-Abortion Movement*, 74.
9 Ibid., 73.
10 "Operation Rescue - Rhode Island Rally," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, OF-1ZSA-1, Box 3, Folder 5, Brown University Library.
11 "Operation Rescue - Rhode Island Rally," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
12 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
13 Rankin, *Bodies on the Line*, 23.
14 Ibid.
15 Ibid., 18.
16 "50th Reunion, Class of 1973," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*, Brown Digital Repository, Brown University Library, https://repository.library.brown.edu/studio/item/bdr:sxcn9fvy/.
17 Ibid.
18 Saurette and Gordon, *The Changing Voice of the Anti-Abortion Movement*, 91.
19 Elizabeth Arndorfer et al., *Who Decides?*, 109.

The Women's Medical Center of Rhode Island in Providence, initially located at 100 Highland Avenue until 1989, was especially vulnerable to anti-abortion protests due to its open location and layout. Unlike the Planned Parenthood Providence Health Center, situated in a more shielded downtown office building on the third floor, the Women's Medical Center was directly accessible from the street.[20] Protesters frequently gathered outside, and their chants were audible even inside the clinic's waiting room, creating an intimidating atmosphere for patients.[21] The clinic's heightened visibility, coupled with its role in providing a significant number of abortions in the state, made the Women's Medical Center a prime target for anti-abortion protests. In a directions sheet to reproductive healthcare facilities in Providence, including Planned Parenthood and Women's Surgical Services, only the Women's Medical Center is described with a specific warning: "a red, brick building on the right; you'll see strange signs and people on the sidewalk."[22] This phrasing functions as a euphemism hinting at the persistent presence of protesters. The combination of the clinic's exposure with its central role in abortion services highlighted the urgent necessity for dedicated clinic escorts to help ensure patients' safe passage into the facility.

Women of Brown United (WBU), a feminist group founded at Brown University in 1970, played a critical role in supporting abortion rights and patients seeking care at Rhode Island clinics. WBU helped establish the Rhode Island Coalition to Repeal Abortion Laws, which successfully overturned restrictive abortion laws in Rhode Island through a class action lawsuit that reached the state Supreme Court in 1973.[23] This victory paved the way for further activism in the state. In November 1985, the Women's Political Task Force of WBU established the WES at the Women's Medical Center.[24] The initiative aimed to ensure patients could safely navigate crowds of anti-abortion protesters to enter the clinic. Additionally, the group began documenting any violent actions and confrontations with protesters. From November 1985 to August 1986, members maintained a detailed chronology of incidents, further supplemented by oral histories and log entries recorded from 1988 to 1990.[25] These records provide valuable evidence of the intensity of the opposition and the necessity of organized, volunteer-based escort services.

Recruitment for the WES primarily occurred through flyers posted around Brown University's campus, displayed in common areas such as the post office and advertised in the *Brown Daily Herald* calendar. Despite early pushback, including the removal of flyers and a few "specifically [being] replaced with Bible study" notices, as well as concerns over personal harassment due to publicly listed contact details, the WES proved successful at recruiting new members.[26] By October 1986, nearly 50 students, 42 women and eight men, had been trained as clinic escorts, a number that continued to grow to almost 200 trained escorts in 1989.[27] This grassroots mobilization, led by a few college students who devoted chunks of their weekends to the cause all year round, laid the foundation for the WES to become an essential presence at the Women's Medical Center.

Not So Black and White: The Role of Clinic Escorts as Silent Allies

As anti-abortion groups became more organized and vocal in their protests, clinic escorts responded by strengthening their coordination and commitment to a non-confrontational stance. Often serving as the public "face" of abortion clinics, escorts were the ones who most frequently interacted with protesters.[28] Still, this visibility raises an important question: what did this "face" convey, and was it one that explicitly and loudly advocated for abortion? Despite their tense and frequent interactions with protesters, members of the WES deliberately avoided confrontation and refrained from openly promoting pro-choice views to patients. Instead, they adhered to a strict policy of non-engagement, positioning themselves as neutral and supportive figures—a stark contrast to the volatility of the protesters.

20 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.
21 Ibid.
22 "Directions - Hold Onto This!," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, OF-1ZSA-1, Box 3, Folder 4, Brown University Library.
23 Mimi Pichey, "A History of Women of Brown United (1970-1991)," *Pembroke Center for Teaching and Research on Women*, Brown Digital Repository, Brown University Library, 2020, 4.
24 Ibid., 5.
25 Pichey, "A History of Women of Brown United," 40.
26 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.
27 Pichey, "A History of Women of Brown United," 40; "Mistress List 5-6-86," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, OF-1ZSA-1, Box 3, Folder 4, Brown University Library; "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection.*
28 Shara Crookston, *Protecting Abortion Access: The Experiences of Clinic Volunteers From Roe to Dobbs* (Lexington Books, 2023), 47.

Examining the roles and guiding principles of clinic escorts reveals their core function as silent, reassuring allies. Escorts were instructed to arrive at the clinic early, around 7:15 a.m., put on yellow pinnies for identification, and station themselves strategically near driveways or entrances. Though patients were often advised to enter through a backdoor to avoid direct confrontation with protesters, some patients forgot these instructions, having received them a week prior. To ensure patients received the necessary support regardless of their route, each shift consisted of six escorts working in pairs, with two typically stationed inside the front door to greet patients as they entered.[29] Their role was similar to that of traffic cops, as escorts "spen[t] much of their time helping people get in and out of the parking lot."[30] One of the most notable instructions in the WES' "Do's and Don'ts" document cautioned them against touching patients, instead suggesting they offer an arm for assistance to avoid being accused of coercing patients into abortions by protesters.[31] Escorts were also instructed not to denigrate the protesters in front of patients, as "patients, as well as the friends and relatives accompanying them, have a variety of feelings about abortion and why they're getting abor-tions." [32] This was particularly important, as one escort recounted an extreme case involving a patient who admitted that she "would've been out there with [the protesters] if she didn't have three kids at home."[33] Instead of making disparaging remarks against the protesters, escorts were encouraged to offer reassuring instructions and make friendly small talk with patients to help drown out protesters' heckling. These protocols provided both a corporeal shield and a supportive presence, ensuring escorts served as neutral buffers for patients navigating a high-stress situation and allowing them to make their own decisions with confidence.



Figure 1. Caricature of an escort at work. From "Say! Ever found yourself standing outside a building in Cranston … with lots of people yelling at you?," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.

WES guidelines stressed avoiding arguments, no matter the protesters' provocations—from cajoling insults to aggressive questioning or even off-key singing.[34] Instead of engaging in debates, they were encouraged to converse with fellow escorts in order to stay focused; a key reason for why they were to operate in pairs. Escorts were also tasked with maintaining a physical distance between protesters, themselves, and patients, as it was against the law for protesters to touch anyone.[35] The caricature shown in Figure 1, created for use by the WES, vividly captures the fraught dynamics that escorts navigate. It depicts an escort leading a patient into the clinic while protesters shout insults, hold signs, and sing hymns. The patient's male companion angrily retaliates with expletives, seemingly against the patient's wishes, as she pleads in visible distress. Notably, the escort is the only figure without a speech bubble, a visual choice that reflects escorts being neutral, non-confrontational figures. As escorts were explicitly advised not to interfere with "escortees" who chose to respond to protesters, they occupied an emotionally liminal space, offering support without escalating confrontation.[36]

29 "Brown Daily Herald 18 (1986-02-14)." *Brown Daily Herald*. Brown Digital Repository, Brown University Library. Accessed November 18, 2024. https://repository.library.brown.edu/studio/item/bdr:969288/.
30 Herman, Lily. 2017. "Clinic Escorts Explain What Pro-Choice Allies Get Wrong." *Glamour*. July 31, 2017. https://www.glamour.com/story/clinic-escorts-explain-pro-choice-allies-get-wrong.
31 "Say! Ever found yourself standing outside a building in Cranston … with lots of people yelling at you?," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, Box 3, Folder 4, Brown University Library.
32 Ibid.
33 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.
34 "Say! Ever found yourself standing outside a building in Cranston … with lots of people yelling at you?," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
35 "Brown Daily Herald 18 (1986-02-14)," *Brown Daily Herald*.
36 "Say! Ever found yourself standing outside a building in Cranston … with lots of people yelling at you?," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.

Given the heightened climate of anti-choice activism, escorts expected protesters to engage in more disruptive actions, such as stepping onto the property, throwing or dropping objects, or loitering in driveways to block entering cars.[37] In these cases, escorts were to calmly inform the individual that the clinic was private property and that the police would be called—all while still maintaining their primary duty of supporting patients. Despite the numerical advantage of the protesters—sometimes 40 to 50 compared to only six escorts on busy days—escorts had the added support of a security guard. However, the security guard at times proved to be more of a hindrance than a help, struggling to cooperate with the escorts' neutral role.[38] Log entries from July and August 1989 describe a security guard named Bill, who frequently threatened to "bash protesters' faces in" and engaged in "futile" conversations with them, which made the escorts nervous about his potential for escalation.[39] Although escorts vented their frustrations with protesters in the logs, referring to themselves as the "good guys" and the protesters as the "bad guys," "assholes supreme," or "the really uncool, gross people"—among other colorful terms—for them, it was not "a competitive game" between 'good' and 'bad,' nor was it about winning or losing; an escort's job was simply to assist people in getting inside the clinic.[40] The eventual replacement of Bill with a more respectful guard was met with a sense of relief, underscoring the importance of maintaining professional neutrality.[41]

The logistics of clinic escorting, as reflected in actual accounts of their work, demonstrate the practical application of the commitment to non-engagement outlined in the guidelines. The non-engagement policy extended to how escorts handled materials distributed by protesters, as they did not prevent patients from accepting any pamphlets. This neutral stance reflected the delicate balance escorts maintained—being present and supportive of patients while avoiding actions that could escalate tensions or appear aggressive. Yet this neutrality often placed escorts in a challenging position, particularly when anti-abortion protesters misinterpreted their roles. One escort, Sarah Fast, described the internal tension of being misconstrued, distancing herself from an ideological pro-abortion stance:

> But I'm saying the reason I'm there, the reason all the people who escort are there, is merely to provide women the chance to choose. The fundamental right to the control of their own bodies, and yet with the protesters there screaming "You don't have to have–you shouldn't have an abortion," and I'm saying, "You can have an abortion if you want," it almost–I lose sight of the fundamental fact. All I'm there to do is provide a woman with control of her own body, and I don't want to say, "You've got to–you should have an abortion." I find myself at times almost pitching for the abortion, which, I don't care if she has an abortion.[42]

Such a statement underscores how escorts understood the nuanced purpose and stakes of their volunteer work, which was not about engaging with protesters or promoting discursive positions. Regardless, protesters often framed the escorts' actions in binary terms. As escort Karen Brown observed, "[protesters] make it such a dichotomous situation, and it's so black and white for them," oversimplifying the escorts' views as: "We want people to have abortions. We are upset when someone comes out and decides that they don't want to go through with it."[43] By framing it in "win/lose terms," every woman who entered the clinic became another mark on the tally for the WES according to protesters.[44] Many escorts expressed feeling as though they were painted as the ones "actually performing the abortion, and [...] having the power" to persuade patients, when in reality, they simply wanted patients to have the opportunity to choose and to carry out that choice safely.[45]

Navigating Violence, Sacrifice, and the Pursuit of Accessible Abortion

Abortion clinic escorts faced a relentless and dangerous reality, standing on the frontlines of a fiercely polarized issue, bearing the weight of violent protests, bigotry,

37 "Say! Ever found yourself standing outside a building in Cranston … with lots of people yelling at you?," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
38 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
39 Ibid.
40 "Say! Ever found yourself standing outside a building in Cranston … with lots of people yelling at you?," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
41 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
42 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," Pembroke Center Oral History Collection.
43 Ibid.
44 Ibid.
45 Ibid.

and psychological strains. Yet, despite the dangers to their own well-being, the WES remained resolute in their mission to ensure that the fundamental right to choose remained intact. Their work, fraught with risks and personal sacrifice, was driven by an unwavering sense of purpose that motivated them to continue their work in the face of relentless opposition.

In 1986, instances of protester violence, coupled with intimidation of patients using graphic imagery and verbal abuse, led five Brown University seniors to testify in Superior Court against the protesters at the Women's Medical Center.[46] One such violent incident occurred when a protester named Tom struck someone over the head with a crucifix.[47] The growing aggression highlighted the need for action, prompting the clinic to seek a permanent injunction against demonstrators on the grounds that the "picketing became so intense that women were obstructed from parking in the clinic's private parking lot and entering the [...] building."[48] The injunction created three restricted zones around the clinic to limit the size and movement of protest groups, prohibiting them from obstructing or photographing patients, making excessive noise, and using specific clothing to pose as escorts.[49] Escort work continued to require constant vigilance and courage despite the injunction, as protesters routinely disregarded legal restrictions. Volunteers were warned not to use each other's names in the presence of protesters to prevent being singled out. Diana, a clinic escort, recalled one particularly violent encounter, describing how a protester "yanked [her] sash and threw [her] into a fence."[50] Even more troubling was the relocation of the clinic to Cranston, "one of the most anti-choice neighborhoods in all of Rhode Island," as the injunction was not carried over, and demonstrators continued to view being arrested as a rite of passage and a source of pride.[51] These incidents underscored the ongoing danger and abuse clinic escorts faced as they stood between patients and protesters, enduring physical aggression to safeguard patients navigating one of the most difficult decisions of their lives.

Furthermore, many escorts endured targeted verbal abuse and bigotry aimed at aspects of their identities. Several oral history accounts describe the shock escorts felt upon realizing they had become personal targets of such intense harassment, initially believing the hostility would be directed solely at patients. As one escort noted, they were subjected to "personal abuse and harassment just as much, but in a different way than the women who [we]re using the services."[52] The harassment often focused on physical features, such as their smile or height, but also included personal insults about intelligence, with protesters mocking the escorts' 'wasted' education at Brown University: "$15,000 to learn how to kill."[53] The abuse was frequently intertwined with prejudices, such as anti-Semitism, accusing Jewish escorts of "joining Hitler" in "killing Christian babies" or labelling them as "money-grubbing" based on the false belief they were paid per abortion.[54] One escort, Allison Buckser, recounted her first day when around 40 demonstrators screamed at her, calling her "the moral equivalent of the death guard at Auschwitz."[55] Given her family's Jewish heritage, she reflected that the abuse "hurt so much because it wasn't a game anymore," leaving her to grapple with guilt for having encouraged new escorts to join her in such a threatening environment.[56] Other protesters targeted the escorts for not fulfilling traditional gender roles. Male escorts, and male companions of patients, were told that "real men don't perform abortions" but were instead meant to protect the unborn children.[57] Female escorts, meanwhile, were criticized for denying their womanhood and wasting their beauty and innocence, as they were told they were "supposed to [make] babies, not [kill] them," with some protesters commenting on their 'desirable' Aryan features.[58] These comments reflect how protesters attacked escorts' identities, attempting to undermine their resolve by questioning their worth and choices.

46 "Brown Daily Herald 85 (1986-09-30)." *Brown Daily Herald*. Brown Digital Repository. Brown University Library. https://repository.library.brown.edu/studio/item/bdr:970187/.
47 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.
48 "Brown Daily Herald 85 (1986-09-30)." *Brown Daily Herald*.
49 "Judgment for permanent injunction," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, OF-1ZSA-1, Box 3, Folder 5, Brown University Library.
50 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection.*
51 Ibid.
52 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.
53 Ibid.
54 Ibid.
55 Ibid.
56 Ibid.
57 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records.
58 "Women's Escort Service: Staffer's Logs (1988-1990)," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records; "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," Pembroke Center Oral History Collection.

Despite ongoing harassment and immense stress, the WES volunteers persisted in their work, motivated by the belief that they were doing the right thing for those they escorted. Many started the role as an experiment, including Sarah Fast, who did not identify with the term pro-choice. However, witnessing the psychological abuse the patients endured made her realize the importance of escorts' shielding work. She recalled a particularly difficult experience when she was assigned to escort alone and felt vulnerable as the sole target for protesters' abuse for hours on end. In moments of doubt and exhaustion, she found solace in the feedback from the women she escorted, which a nurse shared with her: "Without exception, the women say how relieved and happy they were to have someone bring them in, to have the escort[s] there, and how it was a comfort to them."[59] Some escorts, despite facing disapproval from their families and grappling with discrepancies between their faith and values, like Catholic escort Nancy Peterson, felt compelled to stay and fight against the inhumane persecution she witnessed, stating: "...it's difficult when [anti-abortion protesters] are invoking a God, and it's not my God."[60] Another escort, Allison, described how the motivation behind her work—specifically, the benefit it had for abortion seekers—helped her stay grounded amid the chaos:

> …I think I in a perverse sort of way I really enjoy escorting. I go down there, and they're yelling and screaming at me, and I don't know. I grew up down South, and so I'm used to their religious fervor, and I feel almost like I'm this tower of strength and all these things, they're yelling and screaming at me, and so they're not abusing the woman and her companion anymore. And I'm taking it all on me, and as long as I can stand up straight under it then I really have beaten them, and I'm doing something really good, and I don't know, sort of the old going into the lion's den. It's like, we're beating the lions every time we go down there because all they're out there is to really cause pain.[61]

The sense of purpose described by Allison reinforces how escorts viewed themselves as shield-bearers, fending off the protesters' verbal and emotional attacks. The metaphor of entering "the lion's den" highlights the personal and emotional risk they took on, yet it also reflects their belief in the moral strength of their actions. As Pamina Gorbach, an escort who proposed starting the WES, emphasized, the escorts prioritized de-escalation over retaliation: "The clinic is not a political arena; it's a situation of personal trauma which we are trying to alleviate [...] If we feel we are ever escalating violence, we will discontinue service."[62] In their role as a martyr-like "tower of strength," the escorts deflected protesters' cruelty and redirected it onto themselves to protect those they escorted. By enduring the attacks without giving in to hostility, the escorts effectively fought back.

The unwavering dedication of escorts left a profound impact on the patients they assisted. Patients frequently expressed gratitude for the escorts' presence, with one patient even asking if she could return as a volunteer herself.[63] Follow-up surveys from 1988 to 1989 highlighted patients' desire for protesters to be removed and for increased security, further validating the need for escorts' support. Even though the surveys did not specifically inquire about the escorts, many women went out of their way to acknowledge their help. One respondent noted, "as this was not [her] first choice, everyone helped make it easier [...], the escorts helped," with other questionnaire responses describing escorts as "wonderful" and "excellent."[64] Though dangerous and personally taxing, the work of escorts often made the difference between safety and chaos, between successfully accessing care and being deterred by protesters. Another respondent, who almost changed her mind due to the shame she felt from the protesters, reflected afterwards that "it was the best choice for right now in [her] life."[65] Clinic escorts were not only protecting access to a physical space—they were safeguarding the emotional well-being of individuals navigating a deeply personal and often traumatic decision. As one escort, Kirn Bohen, simply put it: "It helps to have someone there to show you where the door is."[66]

Conclusion

Like many other similar grassroots efforts during the

59 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.
60 Ibid.
61 Ibid.
62 "Brown Daily Herald 18 (1986-02-14)," *Brown Daily Herald*.
63 Ibid.
64 "Patient follow-up questionnaires for women who had abortions, 1989," Sarah Doyle Center for Women and Gender records, OF-1ZSA-1, Box 3, Folder 5, Brown University Library.
65 Ibid.
66 "Brown Daily Herald 18 (1986-02-14)," *Brown Daily Herald*.

1980s and 1990s, the WES represented a pivotal form of resistance during a critical period for reproductive rights in the United States. By the late 1980s, clinic escort services had become essential to abortion access in the United States. Although anti-abortion organizations saw a decline in participation by the early 1990s—largely due to legal injunctions, increased law enforcement, and shifting political attitudes—these changes were only possible because clinics continued to operate with the support of committed staff, defenders, and escorts. During a period of growing polarization of the abortion debate, when "clinics had been left to languish by the federal government and law enforcement," it was the escorts who consistently "showed up" to ensure patients could safely access care.[67] Their decision to adopt a neutral stance, refusing to escalate tensions with anti-abortion protesters while still steadfastly supporting patients, helped to preserve a space where women could exercise their autonomy. Their silent ally role challenges the often binary, all-or-nothing view of activism—one that centers loud, visible confrontation while marginalizing quiet, invisible work—by highlighting that both forms of activism are necessary and complementary in the multifaceted fight for reproductive rights. The presence of clinic escorts like the WES was, and remains, a vital support in the face of persistent opposition.

Reflecting on this historical moment, the recent overturning of *Roe v. Wade* has made the hope for a future without the need for clinic escorts feel increasingly distant. What was once imagined as a potentially temporary safeguard has now become an enduring necessity. As one participant in the oral history collection, Karen Brown, expressed, "hopefully [escorting] is going to be going on, [...] whenever anyone looking [sic] at this tape, or hopefully there'll be no need for escorting, which, that would be great."[68] At the time, this statement reflected a hope for a future where clinic escorts would no longer be needed and access to reproductive care would be unimpeded. Sadly, that vision remains out of reach. The clinic escort now stands as a testament to resilience—a symbol of the ongoing fight for reproductive freedom, a fight, silent and non-judgmental, that continues despite higher stakes than ever. ✳

67 Crookston, *Protecting Abortion Access*, 11.
68 "Women's Escort Service, 1988-1989," *Pembroke Center Oral History Collection*.

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